Disability Wage Gap Final Paper - ECON 185

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Abstract

Using American Community Survey data from 2015 to 2024, this project analyzes the persistence of the disability wage gap in full-time working adults. Linear regression models and Oaxaca decompositions were performed to evaluate differences in both observed characteristics and returns to those characteristics between disabled and non-disabled workers. Analyses were separated by gender, which allowed for closer examination of the intersection between gender and disability. The results show that the disability wage gap remains substantial in men and women over the sample period. A large majority of the gap is unexplained by observable characteristics. The regression results further indicate that disabled workers experience lower returns to key factors such as education, age, and work from home status. While education accounts for the largest share of the explained component, its contribution declines over time. In contrast, the role of working from home increases sharply during 2020-2021, reflecting the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic. However, the WFH component diminishes in subsequent years. The findings in this project suggest that the disability wage gap is driven by both differences in characteristics and significantly lower returns to those characteristics, which may reflect potential discrimination.

1 Introduction

1.1 Literature Review

According to the United States Census Bureau (2019), full-time workers with disabilities earn about 87 cents for very dollar made by non-disabled workers. The disability pay gap is also present in multiple countries outside of the US, and persists despite various factors such as productivity and minimum wage increases (Ballo, 2023; Jones, 2024; Kim et al., 2024; Liao et al., 2024; Longhi et al., 2012). The gap can also emerge early in young adults (Mann and Wittenburg, 2015). Therefore, it's important to identify contributing factors.

The disability wage gap persists after controlling for various contributing factors. Kruse et al. (2018) examines whether impairments to job productivity explains the gap. Using American Community Survey data for 2008-2014 and O*Net data on occupational job requirements, Kruse et al. (2018) found that the disablity wage gap is only partially due to productivity impairments. After accounting for job requirements, the disaiblity pay gap remained, which indicates that "productivity limiting job requirements do not fully explain the lower earnings of employees with disabilities" (Kruse et al., 2018). These results suggest potential for discrimination. An additional Oaxaca-Blinder decomposition estimated that 80% or more of the disability wage gap is unexplained.

Despite minimum wage increases, the disability wage gap also remains. Clemens et al. (2026) found that "large minimum-wage changes have substantially more negative impacts on labor-market outcomes for working-age adults with severe disabilities than for working-age adults with either nonsevere disabilities or without disabilities." Focusing on cognitive disabilities, Chiswick et al. (2025) estimates decreases in employment and labor force participation following an increase in minimum wage. A one dollar increase in minimum wage was associated with a 2.5-5.1 percent decrease in employment and a 2.0-3.5 percent decrease in labor force participation for

people with cogntive disabilities. This negative effect is heightened by lower levels of education, which Chiswick et al. (2025) believe reflects lower labor market productivity for people with cognitive disabilities. "The effects appear to be larger in states that relied more heavily on subminimum wages for disabled individuals, although those differences were not statistically significant" (Chiswick et al., 2025). Subminimum wages are allowed under Section 14(c) of the Fair Labor Standards Act (FLSA), which allows employers to pay workers with disabilities less than the minimum wage if their disability limits their performance (FLS, 1938). These reduced earnings were designed to increase employment opportunities for disabled workers, but Chiswick et al. (2025) reports contrary evidence in regards to their benefits.

Ballo (2023) finds that disabled women face the greatest absolute disadvantage. Although the relative disability wage gap is statistically larger for men, Ballo clarifies that this is primarily due to the high baseline earnings of non-disabled men. Women overall earn less than men. Disability acts as a compounding barrier that intersects with existing gendered pay disparities, resulting in a persistent wage gap that remains even after controlling for education and occupation.

Substantial gender differences were also detected by Hallock et al. (2022). They extended wage-only gap analyses by examining total compensation (wages and benefits), and found that "men with a disability earn 12.3% less in benefits than men without a disability, while women with a disability earn 16.6% less in benefits than women without a disability" (Hallock et al., 2022). An Oaxaca decomposition estimated that a majority of the disability pay gap for men is explained by observable factors (e.g. education, experience, race, and occupation). In contrast, the gap for women is explained by almost none of the observed characteristics in the model. These negative returns are not linked to their education or choice of occupation, suggesting high potential for discrimination or unobserved productivity barriers. Their overall findings indicate that the disability wage gap is significantly larger when considering total compensation, which suggests that wage-only analyses may overlook a sizable portion of labor market inequality.

After the COVID-19 pandemic, studies have examined how the shift to working from home has and will impact the disability wage gap. Schur et al. (2020) performed regressions using pre-COVID data to predict work-from-home trends. Their findings show that remote work may expand employment opportunities, but it does not inherently resolve wage disparities. The disability wage gap seems to remain in both home-based and on-site work environments, which indicates that the pay inequality is not solely based on physical workplace barriers.

In their working paper, Bloom et al. (2024) also analyze the impacts of working from home. They find that "the post-pandemic increase in working from home explains 68%-85% of the rise in full-time employment." However, they observe a relative decline in wages within high-WFH occupations. The authors attribute this decline to a supply shift where remote positions have encouraged an influx of disabled individuals to prioritize flexibility and accessibility over higher wages.

1.2 Research Question

The literature illustrates that the disability wage gap persists after controlling for various factors including limited productivity, total compensation, and minimum wage increases (Chiswick et al., 2025; Clemens et al., 2026; Hallock et al., 2022; Kruse et al., 2018). The disability wage gap also seems to intersect with gender pay disparities, leading to disabled women experiencing greater disadvantages (Ballo, 2023; Hallock et al., 2022). The rise in work from home positions following the COVID-19 pandemic increased employment opportunities for workers with disabilities, but wage disparities have not resolved (Bloom et al., 2024; Schur et al., 2020).

The present project builds on previous work by focusing on the past ten years of available ACS data (2015-2024). The impacts of the 2020 COVID-19 pandemic will also be examined. The goal of the analyses is to see what observed characteristics contribute to the disability wage gap. This project attempts to answer this question by decomposing the disability gap

into "explained" and "unexplained" factors as well as fitting linear regression models. Separate analyses will also be conducted for men and women in anticipation of already gendered pay inequalities, as discussed in Ballo (2023).

2 Data

The present project utilizes the American Community Survey from 2015 to 2024. Sample restrictions were made to focus on adults ages 25-63 who usually work at least 30 hours per week and worked at least 27 weeks last year. Self-employed earners were also excluded to eliminate under-reporting of wages. The filtered dataset includes 9,821,723 workers. Descriptive statistics are discussed in the Results section.

The ACS provides data on cognitive difficulty, ambulatory difficulty, independent living difficulty, self-care difficulty, vision/hearing difficulty, vision difficulty, and hearing difficulty. The survey collects this information by asking the following questions:

- Cognitive difficulty: "Because of a physical, mental, or emotional condition, does this person have serious difficulty concentrating, remembering, or making decisions?"
- Ambulatory difficulty: "Does this person have serious difficulty walking or climbing stairs?"
- Independent living difficulty: "Because of a physical, mental, or emotional condition, does this person have difficulty doing errands alone such as visiting a doctor's office or shopping?"
- Self-care difficulty: "Does this person have difficulty dressing or bathing?"
- Vision difficulty: "Is this person blind or does he/she have serious difficulty seeing even when wearing glasses?"
- Hearing difficulty: "Is this person deaf or does he/she have serious difficulty hearing?"

An aggregate disability variable was created to indicate the presence of any disabilities described by the questions above. A disability type variable was also created to examine the how prevalent different disabilites are.

Using the survey question on means of transportation to work, the work from home indicator variable was created. Other binary variables include sex and marriage status. Income was modified into log wage, and education in years was calculated using the median of education intervals available in the ACS data.

3 Methods

First, log wage was estimated using the following equation for females and males, separately:

$$\begin{aligned}
\log(wage) = \beta_0 + Disability \times (\beta_1 Education + \beta_2 Age + \beta_3 Hours + \beta_4 WFH) \quad (1)\\
+ \beta_5 Married + \beta_6 Year + \beta_7 State \quad (2)\\
+ \beta_8 Disability + \beta_9 Education + \beta_{10} Age \quad (3)\\
+ \beta_{11} Hours + \beta_{12} WFH + \epsilon \quad (4)
\end{aligned}$$

The estimated coefficient values are displayed in Table 4.

A twofold Oaxaca-Blinder decomposition was performed using the same variables as controls. Non-disabled people were used as the reference group. In addition to analyzing the full dataset,

separate decompositions were conducted for males and females. The wage gap is visualized in Figures 2 and 3. The total wage gap and percent explained/unexplained are presented in Tables 5 and 6.

4 Results

4.1 Descriptive Statistics

Table 1: Descriptive Statistics by Gender and Disability Status

	Female		Male		All	
Variable	Disabled	Non-disabled	Disabled	Non-disabled	Disabled	Non-disabled
Log Income	10.53 (0.73)	10.75 (0.73)	10.78 (0.78)	11.01 (0.78)	10.66 (0.77)	10.89 (0.77)
Education (years)	13.66 (2.86)	14.49 (2.78)	13.19 (2.97)	13.94 (3.00)	13.41 (2.93)	14.19 (2.91)
Age	46.90 (11.23)	43.87 (11.05)	47.18 (11.29)	43.66 (10.97)	47.06 (11.26)	43.76 (11.01)
Gender (Female)	–	–	–	–	0.46 (0.50)	0.46 (0.50)
Hours	41.37 (7.58)	41.56 (7.07)	44.16 (9.08)	44.47 (8.54)	42.88 (8.54)	43.13 (8.03)
Married	0.46 (0.50)	0.57 (0.49)	0.57 (0.50)	0.64 (0.48)	0.52 (0.50)	0.61 (0.49)
WFH	0.10 (0.31)	0.11 (0.31)	0.08 (0.27)	0.09 (0.29)	0.09 (0.29)	0.10 (0.30)
Observations	240,692	4,278,804	280,957	5,021,268	521,651	9,300,072

Note: Entries are means with standard deviations in parentheses.

The number of disabled and non-disabled participants throughout 2015-2024 seem consistent, excluding the year 2020 (see Figure 4). Data collection in 2020 was likely affected by the pandemic, which led to a noticeable dip. Overall, the number of non-disabled people ranges from around 900,000-980,000 while the number of disabled people range from around 46,000-65,000, excluding the year 2020 from both measures.

The counts of disability types is shown in Table 2. Cognitive disabilities are the most prevalent followed by hearing only and vision only disabilities. Surprisingly, self-care difficulties are still present after applying sample restrictions designed to include full-time workers, but these disabilites have the lowest count.

Table 1 shows the mean and standard deviation of variables for female, male, and all workers, separated by disability status. On average, disabled workers earn less than non-disabled workers. Disabled women have the lowest log income, and non-disabled men have the highest log income. In contrast, women have higher average years of education compared to their male counterparts.

Average hours worked is higher for all male workers compared to all female workers. The

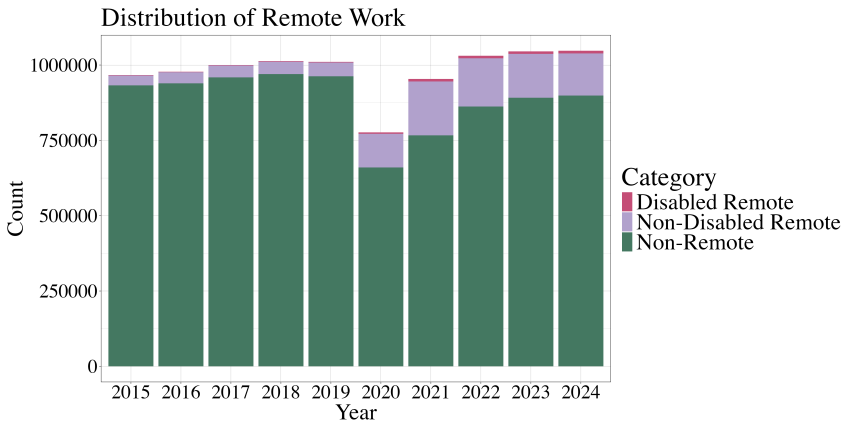
Table 2: Disability Type

Disability Type	Count
Ambulatory	13,210
Hearing Only	120,969
Vision Only	82,599
Cognitive	154,126
Independent Living	20,586
Self-care	4,253
Multiple	8,908
None	9,300,072

Table 3: Counts and Percents of Remote Workers

Year	Disabled: Remote	Non-Disabled: Remote	Total Remote
2015	1535 (3.30%)	32464 (3.53%)	33999 (3.52%)
2016	1727 (3.54%)	36793 (3.96%)	38520 (3.94%)
2017	1921 (3.90%)	39334 (4.14%)	41255 (4.12%)
2018	1916 (3.91%)	41285 (4.28%)	43201 (4.26%)
2019	2131 (4.28%)	45691 (4.76%)	47822 (4.73%)
2020	4592 (11.76%)	112074 (15.20%)	116666 (15.02%)
2021	8256 (15.91%)	178756 (19.82%)	187012 (19.61%)
2022	8435 (14.11%)	159697 (16.45%)	168132 (16.31%)
2023	8331 (13.18%)	145987 (14.86%)	154318 (14.76%)
2024	8427 (13.08%)	139975 (14.24%)	148402 (14.17%)

Figure 1: Distribution of Remote Workers



proportion of female to male workers is similar for disabled and non-disabled people, and the table shows that slighlty more men are in the sample.

Overall, work from home rates are also similar for disabled and non-disabled groups. Detailed counts and percentages of remote workers from 2015 to 2024 are displayed in Table 3. The distribution of remote workers is also visualized in Figure 1. Prior to 2020, the percentages of disabled and non-disabled remote workers are both relatively low, but the percentages dramatically increase for all workers following the 2020 COVID-19 pandemic. However, more non-disabled people work from home during this time. After 2021, the percentages begin to decrease, but they remain larger than pre-COVID work from home rates.

4.2 Linear Regressions

Model 1 in Table 4 presents the coefficient estimates for all female workers, while Model 2 reports results for male workers. Overall, the results indicate that disability is associated with differences in returns for disabled and non-disabled workers.

Based on the interaction term, returns to education, age, hours worked, and work from home status are lower for female disabled workers compared to female non-disabled workers. Similar results are observed in men. Returns to education, age, and work from home status are lower for male disabled workers. However, the interaction between disability and hours worked is small and slightly positive for men (0.1%), which indicates little difference in returns to hours worked by disability status.

The coefficients for education, age, and usual hours worked are similar in magnitude for both men and women, with differences less than 0.01. In contrast, the models show that working from home is associated with higher returns for non-disabled men compared to non-disabled women. A notable difference in returns is also present for marriage. Holding other variables constant, being married is associated with a 26.7% increase in log wages for both disabled and non-disabled men. For women, being married is associated with only a 10.9% increase in log wages.

Both models include state and year fixed effects to control for geographic and temporal differences. With fixed effects included, the estimated coefficients reflect differences within the same state and year.

Excluding the interaction between disability and hours worked, all coefficient estimates in Table 4 are statistically significant. The results suggest that the disability wage gap reflects not only differences in observable characteristics, but also reduced returns for these characteristics.

Table 4: Linear Models

	Dependent Variable: Log Wage	
	(1)	(2)
	Female	Male
Disability	0.196***	0.173***
	(0.011)	(0.010)
Education (years)	0.099***	0.093***
	(0.0001)	(0.0001)
Age	0.008***	0.010***
	(0.00003)	(0.00003)
Usual hours worked	0.023***	0.018***
	(0.00004)	(0.00003)
Work from home	0.191***	0.212***
	(0.001)	(0.001)
Married	0.109***	0.267***
	(0.001)	(0.001)
Disability × Education	−0.020***	−0.023***
	(0.0005)	(0.0004)
Disability × Age	−0.0002	−0.001***
	(0.0001)	(0.0001)
Disability × Hours worked	−0.001***	0.001***
	(0.0002)	(0.0001)
Disability × Work from home	−0.009**	−0.001
	(0.004)	(0.005)
Constant	7.644***	8.059***
	(0.004)	(0.003)
State fixed effects	Yes	Yes
Year fixed effects	Yes	Yes
Observations	4,519,498	5,302,225
R^2	0.301	0.295
Adjusted R^2	0.301	0.295
Residual Std. Error	0.613 (df = 4519428)	0.660 (df = 5302155)
F Statistic	28,208.470*** (df = 69; 4519428)	32,209.560*** (df = 69; 5302155)

Note: $^{*}p < 0.1$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$

4.3 Oaxaca Decomposition

4.3.1 Overall Oaxaca Decomposition

Figure 2: Oaxaca Decomposition of Overall Disability Wage Gap

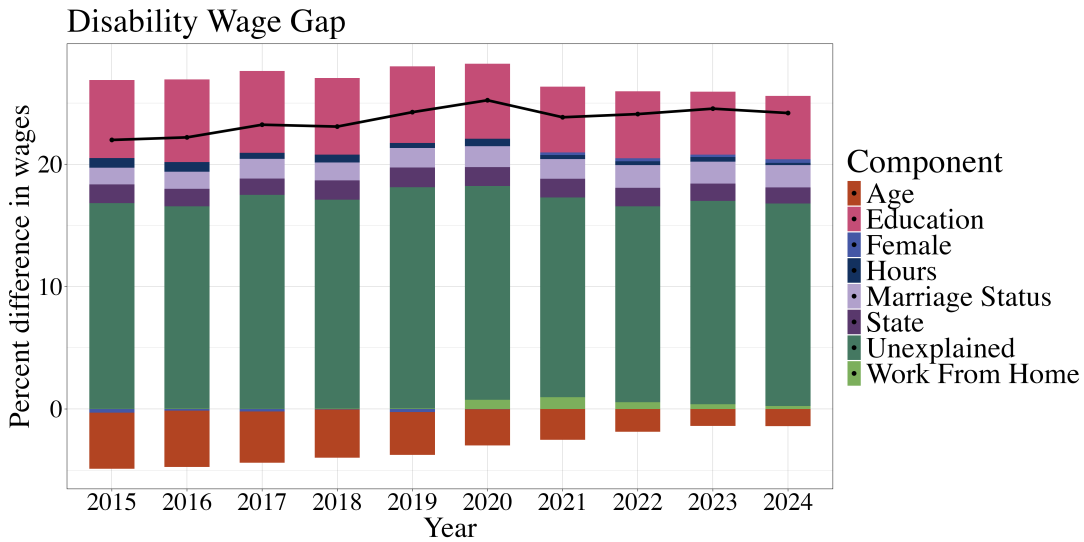


Figure 2 presents the Oaxaca decomposition for all workers. The size of each component in the bar represents that factor's contribution to the disability wage gap, and the black line corresponds to the total wage gap (i.e., the sum of the percent differences).

The overall log wage gap between disabled and non-disabled workers ranges from approximately 22% to 26%. The wage gap appears to increase from 2015 to 2020. Then, it slightly declines, but remains larger than the wage gap prior to 2019.

The largest component is the unexplained portion, which accounts for about 68-77% of the total wage gap. This indicates that the majority of the gap persists after controlling for differences in observed characteristics.

Among the explained portion, differences in education accounts for the largest share. The education component also remains relatively stable over time.

In contrast, the contribution of work from home status is near zero prior to 2020, after which it sharply increases. However, the work from home component gradually decreases after pearking in 2021.

The age component is consistently negative, and rapidly declines over the ten year period. Similarly, the contribution of hours worked also appears to decline over time and remains relatively small. In contrast, the marriage status and state components are stable.

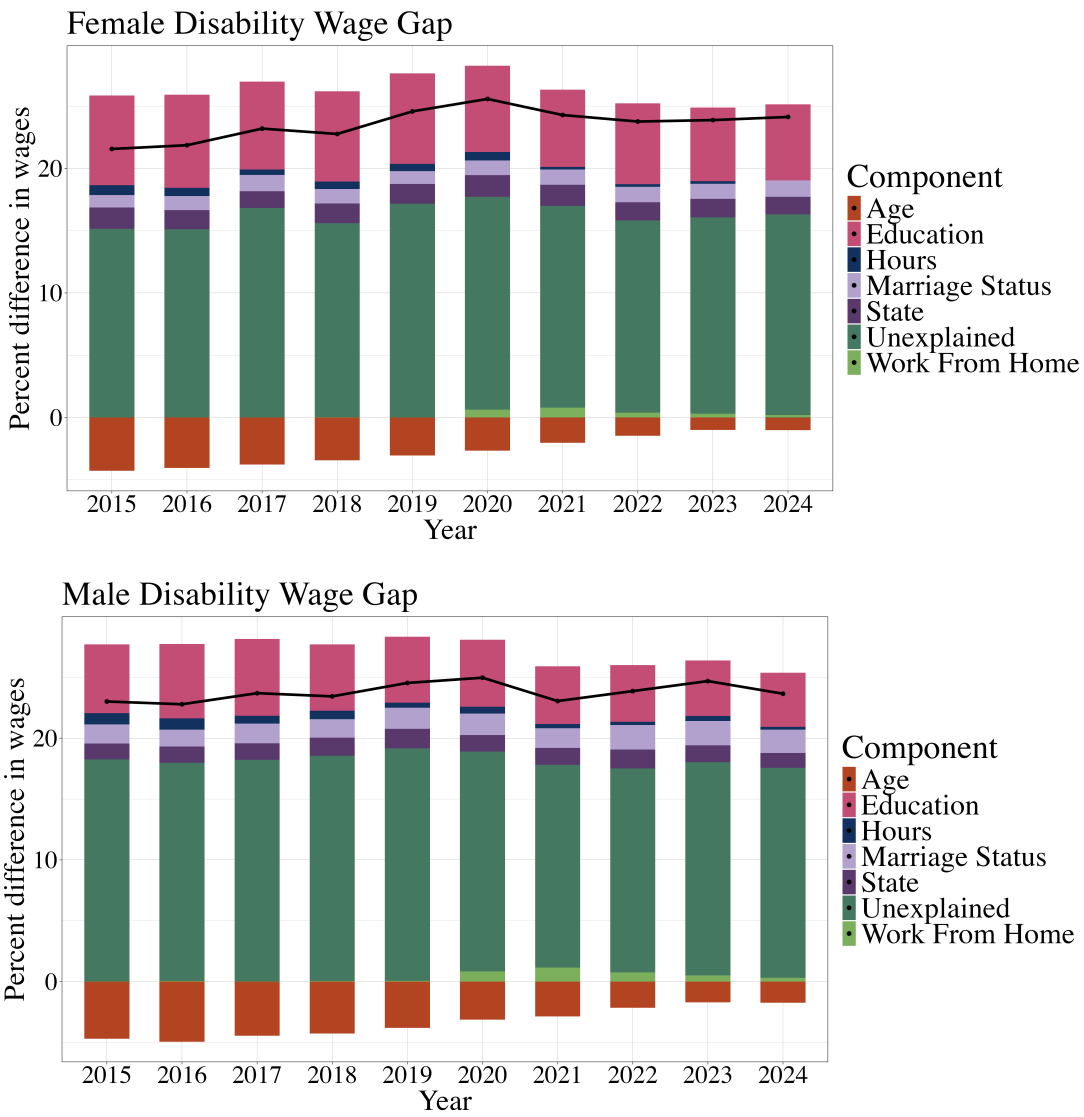
These results reveal that the disability wage gap remains substantial over time, and is largely unexplained by the observed characteristics. The following section presents separate Oaxaca decompositions for men and women, allowing for a more detailed comparison of how the disability pay gap differs across gender.

4.3.2 Female and Male Oaxaca Decompositions

Figure 3 presents the separate Oaxaca decompositions for female and male workers, with corresponding numerical values reported in Tables 5 and 6. Overall, the disability wage gap is similar in magnitude across gender, though its changes over time differs slightly between men and women.

For female workers, the total disability wage gap ranges from approximately 21.6% to 25.6%. The line representing the total wage gap for female workers in Figure 3 closely resembles the

Figure 3: Oaxaca Decomposition of Disability Wage Gap for Females and Males



visualization for all workers. The wage gap increases between 2015 and 2020, but declines slightly and stabilizes afterwards. In the contrast, the decomposition for male workers shows that the total disability wage gap ranges from about 23% to 25%. Unlike the decomposition for women and all workers, the wage gap is comparatiely stable over time with less variation.

The unexplained component accounts for a majority of the wage gap in both groups. Among women, 65-72.6% of the gap is unexplained, and 70.2-79.3% of the gap is unexplained for men. These results reveal how the unexplained share is consistently larger for men, while the explained share plays a relatively greater role among women.

Education is the largest contributor to the explaind component for both groups. However, education explains a larger share of the gap among women than men. Despite this difference in magnitude, the education component gradually declines over time for both groups.

The usual hours worked component also diminishes over time for both men and women, and remains relatively small throughout the ten year period. For women, this component becomes slighlty negative by 2024 (-0.09%).

Age is typically the second largest contributor to the explained component, and remains negative across all years for both groups, suggesting that age differences reduce the overall wage gap. Between 2015 and 2020, the age component is similar for women and women, but it becomes noticeablely smaller for women beginning in 2021.

The marriage and state factors are relatively stable in both men and women. However, marriage accounts for a larger share of the explained component among men (6-8.5%) than among women (4.2-5.6%).

In men and women, the contribution of work from home status to the disability wage gap is near zero prior to 2020, after which it suddenly increases. The WFH component peaks in 2021 before steadily decreases afterwards. This pattern is similar across gender, but the share explained by working from home is slightly larger for men compared to women.

Overall, while the magnitude of the disability wage gap is comparable between men and women, the contribution of observed characteristics to the gap differs slightly, with the unexplained component accounting for a marginally larger share among men.

Table 5: Female Disability Wage Gap and Percent Explained/Unexplained

Year	Total Gap	Unexplained	Age	Education	Hours	Married	State	WFH
2015	21.56	70.3	-19.9	33.3	3.69	4.65	7.92	0
2016	21.86	69.1	-18.5	34.2	3.02	5.21	6.98	0.03
2017	23.20	72.6	-16.2	30.4	1.86	5.63	5.79	-0.01
2018	22.77	68.5	-15.1	31.9	2.66	5.06	6.95	0.06
2019	24.58	69.8	-12.4	29.6	2.36	4.20	6.40	0.03
2020	25.58	66.8	-10.4	27.1	2.65	4.60	6.79	2.45
2021	24.29	66.7	-8.39	25.5	0.85	5.08	6.96	3.28
2022	23.77	65.0	-6.15	27.3	0.89	5.19	6.14	1.65
2023	23.88	66.0	-4.21	24.7	0.88	5.06	6.25	1.27
2024	24.13	66.8	-4.14	25.3	-0.09	5.48	5.79	0.84

Note: Columns for observed characteristics represent percentage contributions to the total wage gap.

5 Discussion

Across all full-time workers, the disability wage gap is large and persisting. The results of the Oaxaca decompositions show that the gap is mostly unexplained, which aligns with the linear

Table 6: Male Disability Wage Gap and Percent Explained/Unexplained

Year	Total Gap	Unexplained	Age	Education	Hours	Married	State	WFH
2015	23.01	79.3	-20.4	24.6	4.05	6.78	5.72	0.05
2016	22.79	78.7	-21.7	26.8	4.05	6.06	5.88	0.22
2017	23.70	76.8	-18.8	26.6	2.72	6.86	5.74	0.07
2018	23.43	79.0	-18.2	23.3	2.92	6.51	6.30	0.21
2019	24.54	77.8	-15.4	22.1	1.67	7.09	6.49	0.28
2020	24.97	72.3	-12.5	22.0	2.24	7.11	5.43	3.38
2021	23.05	72.2	-12.4	20.6	1.55	7.01	5.99	5.06
2022	23.87	70.2	-8.97	19.5	1.13	8.47	6.51	3.19
2023	24.69	70.9	-6.86	18.5	1.63	8.13	5.62	2.05
2024	23.65	72.9	-7.32	18.8	1.00	8.12	5.16	1.34

Note: Columns for observed characteristics represent percentage contributions to the total wage gap.

regression findings. In addition to having differences in observed characteristics, disabled and non-disabled groups experience different returns to these characteristics.

The largest explained component in each decomposition is education. However, the contribution of education declines over the ten year period, suggesting that disparities in educational attainment are becoming less important in explaining the disability wage gap over time. In spite of that, the linear regression results show that returns to education are consistently lower for disabled workers. Both the Oaxaca decomposition and linear model results indicate that while eduation remains an important factor, it is not sufficient to close the wage gap. If disabled workers attained similar levels of education, they would still receive lower returns, which points to barriers that limit the wages of disabled workers.

Age is typically the second largest contributor to the explained portion, but it is remains negative for the entire period. Therefore, age helps reduce the wage gap. These results are consistent with the logic that older and more experienced workers earn a higher income. The average age of disabled workers is higher than non-disabled workers, which increases the wage for disabled workers. However, the age component declines over time, suggesting the average age between groups may be converging. It's also possible that the returns to age are declining.

Gender differences are particularly evident when examining marriage status. The linear regression models indicate substantially higher returns to marriage for men than for women. The estimated coefficient for men is nearly double that of women. These results are consistent with traditional household views and employer perceptions that favor married men as primary earners. In contrast, the smaller returns for women may reflect differences in employment decisions, occupational sorting, or workplace biases that limit the income of married women. The Oaxaca decompositions further show that marriage accounts for a larger share of the explained component among men than women, which suggests that marriage status interacts differently with disability across gender. The decomposition highlights an additional layer of inequality at the intersection of gender and disability.

The ten year period spanning 2015 to 2024 provides the opportunity to examine how the COVID-19 pandemic impacted the disability wage gap. The positive contribution of work from home status in the Oaxaca decompositions indicates that differences in remote work participation between disabled and non-disabled workers widened the wage gap during the pandemic. Based on these results, it's likely that while remote work quickly expanded, disabled workers did not benefit proportionately from this shift in terms of access to higher-paying remote positions. The influx of non-disabled workers to remote positions likely increased the average log income, which widened the gap in the decompositions. The regression results further illustrate

that, although working from home is associated with higher wages, the returns to working from home are significantly lower for disabled workers relative to non-disabled workers. Together, the decomposition and regression results suggest that remote work contributes to the disability wage gap through unequal distribution and unequal returns. Disabled workers are less likely to benefit from high-paying WFH opportunities and receive lower wage returns when they do work from home.

The unexplained component consistently accounts for the largest portion of the disability wage gap with approximately 68-77% unexplained in all workers, 65-72.6% unexplained in women, and 70.2-79.3% unexplained in men. Notably, the unexplained share is larger for men than women, further confirming complex gender and disability interactions. The overall persistence of the large unexplained component implies that the observable characteristics cannot fully account for the disability wage gap. Instead, a portion of the gap arises from differences in the returns to those characteristics. While these differences in returns are consistent with the presence of discrimination against people with disabilities, they may also reflect the influence of unobserved factors, such as differences in occupation or disability severity. Overall, these findings suggest that the disability wage gap is driven both by disparities in observable characteristics and lower returns to those characteristics, with the unexplained component signalling potential discrimination.

5.1 Limitations

The American Community Survey does not provide information on the severity of disabilites. Participants also cannot indicate if their disability is acquired or congenital. Without these measurements, the analysis cannot accurately examine how varying disabilities impact the wage gap. The severity could greatly impact what positions are suitable for certain individuals. The presence of a disability earlier in life can also impact other explanatory variables such as education.

Another limitation is the lack of occupation type as a control in the analysis. Pay disparities may differ across occupation, which should be examined by future work.

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6 Appendix
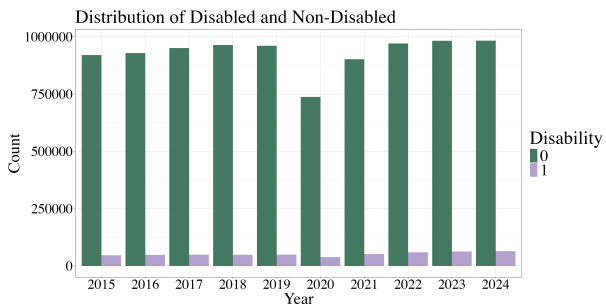
Figure 4: Distribution of Disabled and Non-Disabled Participants